

account for inflation, this company would be worth over \$7 trillion in today's money.

They became very successful for spice trading in the Republic of Indonesia. The Dutch had a monopoly with their government that lasted over 20 years and helped keep them as an attractive option to investors — after all, when you see a government jump in to help a private company stay afloat, investors often assume the company is less likely to fail.

They decided they'd offer shares to the general public through the Amsterdam Stock Exchange to help fund their business, becoming the first publicly listed company to sell shares to retail investors (people like you and me). They raised 6.5 million guilders to then fund their explorations. It was a successful IPO to say the least.

I do want to take a moment to acknowledge that when we speak about history, we cannot erase the problems with explorations such as these. The Dutch East India Company also engaged in the trading of enslaved people and displacing African and Asian people as part of its business model. It was entirely unethical and inhumane, and had lasting effects on the economies and wealth of the countries they targeted.

The Dutch East India Company also played a huge role in the stock market's first economic bubble. A bubble, like the Dotcom Bubble mentioned in [chapter 2](#), is when the price of something keeps getting higher and higher based on speculation, ultimately becoming unsustainable and quickly dropping in price. But the first bubble wasn't actually based around a single stock — it was about flowers. Tulips, to be exact.

I've never come across a bunch of tulips I haven't considered beautiful, but my feelings towards them pale in comparison to those of the Dutch in the sixteenth century. They were so prized that, at the peak of the bubble, some tulip bulbs were being sold for six times the average person's annual salary at the time.

It all began when tulips were imported into Europe from Turkey thanks to the spice trade routes. They were seen as a status symbol because they were so fragile. Originally only a prize for the wealthy, they quickly became popular among the middle class as well. All types of tulips were being traded, with multicoloured ones perceived as being even rarer and more